

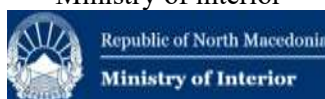
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ТЕХНОЛОГИИ, ОТПОРНИ ОПШТЕСТВА,
РИЗИЦИ И ПРЕДИЗВИЦИ**

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THE FLAG IS NOT DECORATION: WRONG FLAG DISPLAY AS A PROTOCOL BREACH AND SECURITY COMMUNICATION FAILURE

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Abstract

The national flag is a legally protected state emblem and a highly visible instrument of diplomatic communication, not a ceremonial accessory. This paper examines wrong flag display as a protocol breach and as a security-communication failure that can damage institutional credibility regardless of intent. It combines normative analysis of the domestic, military and international framework with qualitative case-study analysis of seven publicly documented incidents involving the Republic of North Macedonia, one detailed international comparator and two concise comparative examples. The analysis identifies recurring mechanisms of failure: substitution of visually similar flags, incorrect orientation, weak final inspection, fragmented responsibility and the absence of an independent four-eyes verification procedure. The cases show that a short visual error can become a durable public message through media circulation, diplomatic interpretation and reputational amplification. The paper concludes that prevention requires not ad hoc apologies but an integrated institutional risk-management model: standardised flag inventory, assigned accountability, written placement diagrams, independent final verification and scenario-based training. Its practical contribution is an operational guide for protocol officers grounded in Articles 16-24 of the Law and the Military Protocol Rulebook.

Keywords: *flag, protocol breach, diplomatic protocol, political semiotics, security communication*

1. INTRODUCTION

The flag is one of the most visible and symbolically sensitive state emblems. In state and diplomatic protocol, its use is never a matter of decoration, but of legal status, symbolic accuracy, institutional discipline and state reputation. When the wrong flag appears during an official welcome, the playing of anthems or a bilateral meeting, the public and the foreign party do not see the organisational background of the error; they see the final image, and that image circulates long after the substantive content of the visit has been forgotten.

In recent decades, the Republic of North Macedonia has experienced a series of such incidents — some minor, some triggering diplomatic reactions, formal apologies and media storms. Each poses the same question: why do such errors occur with state symbols that have clear legal regulation and an established tradition of treatment (Zname.mk, n.d.)? The answer is systemic: the absence of a standardised verification procedure, a lack of designated responsible personnel, insufficient training and fragmented institutional oversight. This paper examines those causes, documents the consequences and offers a practical solution.

The phenomenon is not unique to North Macedonia or to smaller administrations. Comparative examples from Ukraine, Switzerland, the United Kingdom, the United States, Australia, the Philippines and China show that flag-protocol failure can occur even in highly resourced diplomatic systems. This recurrence suggests a structural vulnerability: visual similarity, compressed preparation windows and the absence of an independently verified final check are more decisive than the size or prestige of the institution.

The topic also matters because the media environment has changed. A protocol failure once confined to a diplomatic note or a short domestic press item is now photographed within seconds, circulated through social platforms within minutes and preserved online long after the substantive content of the visit has been forgotten. This asymmetry between the short duration of the error and the durability of its digital record explains why a low-cost procedural safeguard deserves serious institutional attention.

2. AIM AND RESEARCH QUESTIONS

The study has a double aim: to systematise the multilevel normative framework governing flag use — spanning domestic law, military protocol and international conventions — and, through analysis of concrete documented cases, to demonstrate that incorrect flag display is not merely a technical error but a symbolic, political and diplomatic phenomenon with measurable consequences.

This research extends the author's earlier work on protocol and security: the doctoral dissertation on protocol and defence diplomacy (Smiljanov, 2021c), the article on (un)intentional protocol mistakes in world diplomacy (Smiljanov, 2021a, pp. 56-70), and the monograph *Diplomacy, Protocol and Security* (Smiljanov, 2021b, pp. 89-96). Those works treated protocol not as ceremonial etiquette alone but as a component of institutional security, public communication and state credibility. The present paper narrows that wider programme to one highly visible symbolic field: state and foreign flags. Its added contribution is to connect legal analysis, political semiotics, comparative evidence and a practical integrated checklist into one coherent model that can be evaluated academically and applied operationally by protocol services.

The originality of the study lies in treating flag display as a low-cost but high-visibility field of security communication. Most discussions of state symbols remain either legalistic, ceremonial or descriptive. This paper connects those levels into a single analytical chain: legal rule, protocol execution, visual perception, media circulation and institutional consequence. That chain is especially relevant for small and medium-sized states, where symbolic accuracy often carries disproportionate value for international credibility. The argument is therefore not that flag errors are strategically equivalent to crises, but that they are preventable micro-failures through which institutional seriousness is publicly measured.

The central hypothesis is that flag-protocol violations function as involuntary political communication acts: regardless of intent, they produce reputational, diplomatic and symbolic effects that may be perceived as deliberate discourtesy. This does not mean that every error is political in origin; the claim is more precise: once the image enters public circulation, the distinction between accidental mistake and intentional message becomes less important than the effect produced. The research asks: What rules govern flag use? How are incorrect flags read in diplomatic and political context? When does error become public message? What preventive measures are required? And is the vulnerability local or structural? Sections 3-5 establish the legal, theoretical and methodological frame; section 6 examines the cases; sections 7-10 translate the findings into operational recommendations.

For the purposes of this study, wrong flag display is defined as any publicly visible use of a state or international flag that departs from the legally prescribed, procedurally expected or diplomatically conventional form of identity, orientation, precedence, dimension, height, order or contextual dignity. This definition includes substitution of one state flag for another, inversion, incorrect order in bilateral or multilateral settings, unequal treatment of participating states and use that visually lowers the dignity of the symbol. The definition deliberately excludes purely private mistakes and unverified anecdotes, because the subject of this paper is the point at which procedural failure becomes public communication.

3. LEGAL AND PROTOCOL FRAMEWORK

The use of the flag is governed by a multilevel normative system comprising national law, a military-specific rulebook and international convention. At the national level, the primary source is the Law on the Use of the Coat of Arms, Flag and Anthem of the Republic of Macedonia (Official Gazette No. 32/97, amended 110/08; the legal title of the act is retained as published), complemented by the Rulebook on the Manner of Displaying and Flying the Flag (Official Gazette No. 156/07). A third key instrument, specific to the military domain, is the Military Protocol Rulebook (Trajanoski, 2018), which prescribes exact flag dimensions for different settings, the two-person raising and lowering ceremony, and the rules for table-top flag pennants during bilateral and multilateral meetings.

At the international level, Article 29 of the Vienna Convention on Consular Relations (1963) recognises the sending state's right to fly its flag on consular premises and official vehicles, while paragraph 3 conditions that right on respect for the laws, regulations and usages of the receiving state. Article 20 of the Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations (1961) recognises the same right for diplomatic missions. These provisions do not create a detailed treaty rule requiring the host state to display the visiting state's flag in a particular manner; rather, they reinforce the protocol expectation that state symbols will be treated accurately and with dignity.

A narrower international instrument concerns the flag of the United Nations. The United Nations Flag Code and Regulations (United Nations, 1967) governs the design, dimensions and display conditions of the UN flag itself. It does not operate as a general code for arranging Member States' national flags at multilateral events; that issue remains governed by host-state protocol, domestic law and customary precedence practice. This distinction matters for the multilateral examples in sections 6.4 and 6.6, where national-flag order, height and equality are the core issues.

Article 24 of the Law establishes prohibitions: the flag must not be used as drapery, curtain, covering, or decoration on pillows, napkins, paper boxes, undergarments or disposable items. Article 18 establishes that the flag is raised and lowered with customary honours. Article 19 regulates display on a pole — between sunrise and sunset, with illumination required for continuous twenty-four-hour display. Article 20 prescribes the mandatory honours during raising and lowering: standing to attention facing the flag, removing headwear, rendering a military salute. Article 21 regulates indoor display: to the right of the speaker, with the flag of a local self-government unit placed to the left, at a distance of two metres and one metre lower. Article 22 regulates display on motor vehicles, requiring placement on the right side of the chassis as viewed from the front. Article 23 regulates display at half-mast and on a casket during state and military funerals. Articles 16 and 17 establish the positions for display alongside foreign flags, including alphabetical order, equal dimensions, and the rule that no other flag may be larger or higher than the

national flag, together with the specific spacing rule for a local self-government flag (two metres distance, one metre lower, and the national flag of greater dimension).

This domestic framework is not exceptional in comparative terms. Most states regulate flag display through a combination of statute and customary protocol practice. The Philippines, for instance, codifies its national flag protocol in Republic Act No. 8491, the Flag and Heraldic Code, which — much like Article 16 of the Macedonian Law — mandates that the national flag occupy the position of honour relative to any foreign flag displayed alongside it. The persistence of flag-display violations even under such codified regimes, illustrated in section 6.9 below, suggests that the existence of a legal text is a necessary but insufficient condition for compliance; the missing element, as this paper argues, is operational verification at the point of execution.

Neither the Macedonian Law nor its accompanying Rulebook prescribes a specific sanction, verification procedure or assigned institutional owner for the failures documented in section 6. The legal framework describes the correct end-state but is largely silent on the procedure that confirms, immediately before display, that the correct end-state has been achieved. This is the decisive institutional gap. In practice, a flag can be legally regulated, correctly stored, formally assigned to an event and still be wrong at the moment of display if no officer is responsible for the last visual check. Public debate in 2025, including a proposal to establish a dedicated inspectorate for state insignia, shows that this enforcement gap has been recognised politically (MKD.mk, 2025). The practical problem remains procedural: where responsibility is distributed between protocol offices, archives, honour guards and local organisers, the likelihood of diffusion of responsibility increases (Darley & Latané, 1968). Closing that procedural gap is the organising logic of the guide in section 7.

4. WHY THE FLAG IS NOT DECORATION

The flag is not an ornamental object, but a visual expression of state identity, dignity and sovereignty. Its incorrect use creates an impression of disrespect, personnel unreadiness or institutional improvisation. In diplomatic protocol, the flag functions as a non-verbal communication act — a signal of readiness and respect toward the visiting party. When incorrectly displayed, the message is the opposite of the one intended.

This sensitivity has sociological roots. Durkheim (1912) observed that societies designate certain objects as sacred because they stand for collective identity. The national flag occupies a similar position in the modern state: its value is not material but symbolic, tied to sovereignty and dignity. Mishandling it therefore violates not only a ceremonial rule but also the boundary between what a political community treats as ordinary and what it treats as representative of itself.

This can briefly be situated within the framework of soft power (Nye, 2004) — the capacity of a state to attract and persuade through image rather than coercion, which protocol errors directly undermine. Barston (2014) and Berridge and James (2003) similarly note that protocol, though apparently formal, signals institutional maturity and carries deep political significance in the international context. The more analytically demanding question — why a small visual error carries this much weight in the first place — is taken up next.

A sharper theoretical tool comes from international relations theory. Jervis (1970) distinguishes between signals, which a sender can manipulate deliberately, and indices, which are read as more credible because they are harder to fabricate. A flag-protocol error is an index rather than a signal: no protocol service chooses to commit it, which is precisely why publics and diplomatic counterparts treat it as evidence of institutional readiness or

unreadiness. This is the theoretical core of the paper: the unintentional character of the mistake gives it political weight.

Political symbolism completes the frame. Edelman (1964) explains how political acts acquire meaning through the symbolic environment in which the public receives them; a flag condenses recognition, hierarchy and respect into one visual sign. Goffman (1974) adds that a diplomatic ceremony is an interaction frame with expected elements, and a wrong or misplaced flag breaks that frame. The error is therefore not judged only against its technical cause but against the symbolic order the ceremony was expected to confirm.

The cases in section 6 can be read as repeated empirical instances of this same mechanism. In the Austria/Latvia case, the condensation-symbol function of the flag meant that a single archival mislabelling was read, almost instantly, as a statement about the host state's regard for Austria as a partner, even though no such statement was intended by anyone involved; the frame-violation function meant that the remainder of the welcome ceremony — the honour guard, the anthem, the joint statements — was retrospectively absorbed into the narrative of the error rather than read on its own terms. The same dynamic recurs, in varying intensity, in the Slovenia/Slovakia, Montenegro and Switzerland/Denmark cases: in each, an error that consumed at most a few minutes of preparation time generated days or weeks of public commentary disproportionate to its administrative cause, precisely because the flag's symbolic density converts a minor logistical failure into what observers experience as a statement about the relationship itself.

Digital circulation intensifies this effect. A photograph of a misplaced flag is visually simple, easily shared and resistant to later correction. In the networked public-diplomacy environment described by Pamment (2012), incidental images can shape state image as powerfully as official communication. This is especially relevant to flag errors because they are easily understood by audiences with no specialist knowledge of protocol: the public does not need to read a legal rule to see that the wrong national symbol has been displayed. Subsequent explanations rarely travel as far as the photograph itself. For protocol services, this means that a flag check is no longer a decorative detail; it is a preventive measure against reputational risk and a modest but necessary component of institutional resilience.

5. METHODOLOGY

The study applies a qualitative analytical approach grounded in three pillars: normative analysis of the relevant domestic, military and international framework; comparative interpretation of cases against each other and against international practice; and case-study methodology applied to seven documented incidents involving the Republic of North Macedonia. The normative component identifies what the rules require; the case component examines how failures occur in practice; and the comparative component tests whether similar failures appear outside the author's primary jurisdiction. A detailed international comparator is examined in section 6.8, while section 6.9 adds two concise comparative examples selected for public prominence and verifiability. The comparative examples broaden the discussion but are not treated as part of the core domestic corpus.

The seven core domestic cases were included only where three conditions were jointly satisfied: (1) the incident involved a senior state, diplomatic or institutional representative; (2) the incident achieved public or media visibility sufficient for independent verification; and (3) photographic, video or official confirmation existed in the public record. Cases known only through informal professional memory were deliberately excluded, even

where the author had professional awareness of them, because the purpose of this paper is not anecdotal reconstruction but verifiable analysis. Where Table 1 uses n.d., the public source did not provide a stable date; for such entries, retrieval information is supplied in the reference list. The "documented response" column records what was located in the public record, not a condition every case had to meet. This distinction is important: absence of a public apology does not mean absence of error, and absence of a documented internal reaction does not remove the case's analytical value.

Each case was coded across six analytical dimensions: the type of error, the institutional setting, the visibility of the event, the likely failure mechanism, the documented response and the security-communication effect. The coding was intentionally simple so that the analysis remains transparent and replicable. The aim was not to produce a statistical model, but to identify whether different incidents repeat the same procedural weakness. This approach is appropriate for a small corpus of public cases because the unit of analysis is not the frequency of all hidden errors, but the mechanism by which visible errors become reputational events.

The analysis does not claim statistical representativeness. It relies on media-verified incidents rather than internal audit records, which were not accessible for this study; undocumented or quietly corrected errors are therefore excluded. The documentation is also uneven: high-level incidents produced more evidence than ministerial, municipal or regional events. This limitation is not incidental but structurally important, because it suggests that the cases visible to the public are probably only a portion of the actual risk landscape. At the same time, public visibility is precisely what makes these cases relevant to security communication: once an image becomes public, the reputational effect exists independently of whether the institution recorded the incident internally. The hypothesis is supported by consistency across cases and by theoretical coherence with section 4, not by quantitative testing. A representative quantitative study would require institutional access beyond the scope of this paper.

A conservative source hierarchy was applied throughout. Legal instruments and official rulebooks are used for normative claims; peer-reviewed or established academic works are used for theoretical claims; media sources are used only to document publicly visible incidents and reactions. Where a case depends on media reporting, the text avoids overstating causality and records only what can be supported by the public record. This separation between normative authority, theoretical authority and evidentiary reporting is essential because a protocol study can easily become anecdotal if those layers are not kept distinct.

6. CASE ANALYSES

Before the individual analyses, Table 1 provides a comparative overview of the ten incidents examined: seven core North Macedonian cases, one detailed international comparator and two concise comparative examples. Cases for which the institutional event is confirmed but the protocol irregularity is documented primarily through public reporting or visual material are identified conservatively, without inferring intent.

Table 1. Summary of Analysed Flag-Protocol Incidents

Case	Year	Flags Involved	Error Type	Institutional Level	Documented Response
6.1 Austria/Latvia	2018	Red-white-red similarity	Substitution	Central government	Formal apology
6.2 Slovenia/Slovakia	2022	Blue/red coat-of-arms similarity	Substitution	Ministry of Foreign Affairs	Apology; resignation of protocol director
6.3 Montenegro	2019 (reported)	Heraldic orientation	Inversion	Central government / Presidency	Formal apology; media-reported
6.4 Multilateral institutional setting	2022 (reported)	Order and arrangement	Sequencing / weak verification	Multilateral / institutional	Media-reported; no formal sanction documented
6.5 Bulgaria	2022 (context confirmed)	Tricolour order/orientation	Inversion / incorrect display	Bilateral / neighbouring state	Incident treated cautiously as media/visual record
6.6 Open Balkan, Ohrid	2022	Host-state and partner flags	Sequencing / host-state position	Regional initiative	Visual record assessed under Article 16(1)(4); no formal response documented
6.7 France/Netherlands	2019	Vertical/horizontal bands	Substitution	Municipal (Ohrid)	Not formally documented
6.8 Switzerland/Denmark	2014	White cross on red	Substitution	Host-state national protocol (Ukraine)	Acknowledged informally by principal

Case	Year	Flags Involved	Error Type	Institutional Level	Documented Response
6.9a United Kingdom/United States	2026	UK/Australia similarity; UK flag orientation	Substitution and inversion	National / US host	Street flags corrected; inversion publicly reported
6.9b China/Philippines	2018	Precedence order	Sequencing error	National (host)	Public commentary, no resignation documented

Note. Reported or context-confirmed entries are treated as public-evidence cases, not as formally adjudicated violations. The table distinguishes between a confirmed institutional event, a media-reported protocol irregularity and a visual record assessed against the applicable flag-display rule.

6.1. The Latvian Flag Displayed Instead of the Austrian Flag

On 7 September 2018, during the reception of Austrian Chancellor Sebastian Kurz at the Government building in Skopje, the Latvian flag was displayed instead of the Austrian one during the anthem ceremony (SDK.mk, 2018). The visual similarity of the two red-white-red flags explains why a hurried officer could make the mistake, but it also reveals the absence of a basic verification procedure. Smiljanov (2021a, pp. 61-62; Smiljanov, 2021b, p. 90) notes that such an error can be read as disregard for Austria or as evidence of weak protocol professionalism, even where no such message was intended. Austrian journalists noticed the error before the host protocol service did, which turned a domestic organisational failure into a diplomatic embarrassment observed by the visiting delegation itself. The Government subsequently issued a formal apology. The mistake overshadowed the substantive content of the visit and became the dominant media image of the event.

6.2. The Slovak Flag Displayed Instead of the Slovenian Flag

During the official visit of Slovenian Foreign Minister Tanja Fajon in October 2022, her Macedonian counterpart Bujar Osmani received her at a tête-à-tête meeting where the Slovak flag stood on the table instead of the Slovenian one (SDK.mk, 2022). The flags share a similar white-blue-red composition and differ most visibly in the coat of arms (Fokus.mk, 2022). The correct Slovenian flag appeared at the later press conference, showing that the failure was confined to the smaller bilateral setting. That point is analytically important: reduced format does not reduce symbolic responsibility. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs apologised, and the director of the Ministry's protocol department resigned twelve days later, citing moral responsibility (Libertas.mk, 2022). The case demonstrates that even a table-top flag in a small meeting can trigger institutional accountability when the visiting state symbol is visibly wrong.

6.3. Incorrect Display of the Montenegrin Flag

During the visit of Montenegrin President Milo Đukanović, the Montenegrin flag was publicly reported as having been displayed upside down in an official protocol setting. The incident is important because the Montenegrin flag contains a heraldic emblem whose orientation is immediately readable by the represented state. In such cases, the error is not merely decorative: it visually reverses a state symbol and therefore produces a stronger symbolic disturbance than a minor placement defect. The case is treated here as a media-reported and apology-related incident, not as proof of intentional disrespect (Denar.mk, n.d.; Telma, 2022).

6.4. Incorrectly Arranged Flags in a Multilateral Setting

The wider 2022 public discussion of institutional flag errors in North Macedonia indicates that the problem was not limited to one bilateral substitution. In multilateral or institutional settings, a flag-order mistake affects the entire symbolic architecture of the event: the host must apply a consistent rule for precedence, position, equality of dimensions and visibility. The relevant analytical point is therefore systemic. A single incorrectly ordered row can suggest uneven recognition, weak preparation or uncertainty about the hierarchy of participating states and organisations. For that reason, this case is retained as a media-reported indicator of weak final verification in institutional protocol practice rather than as a formally acknowledged disciplinary case (Telma, 2022).

6.5. Incorrect Display of the Bulgarian Flag

The Bulgarian case is treated with particular caution. The bilateral meetings between the Macedonian and Bulgarian prime ministers in 2022 provide the confirmed political and diplomatic context for a highly sensitive neighbouring-state setting (MIA, 2022). Where the alleged flag irregularity is based on media or visual reporting rather than an official apology or institutional decision, the appropriate academic classification is not "formally confirmed breach" but "media/visual-record protocol incident". This distinction matters because the protocol analysis can identify risk, symbolism and potential diplomatic effect without overstating the evidentiary record. In a Macedonian-Bulgarian context, even a minor tricolour-order or orientation error may receive amplified interpretation because the wider relationship is politically sensitive.

6.6. Incorrectly Displayed Flags at the Open Balkan Summit in Ohrid

The Open Balkan Summit held in Ohrid on 8 June 2022 provides a confirmed regional summit context involving the host prime minister of North Macedonia and leaders from Serbia, Albania, Montenegro and Bosnia and Herzegovina (Blazhevski, 2022). The photographic record submitted for this analysis shows a row of flags in which the Macedonian host-state flag does not appear in the first position from the left as viewed from the front. Under Article 16(1)(4) of the Law on the Use of the Coat of Arms, Flag and Anthem, when the Macedonian flag is displayed in the territory of the state together with flags of other states or international organisations in a row, it should occupy the first position in the row, namely the left side as viewed from the front. The case is therefore best classified as a visually documented flag-order irregularity assessed against the domestic precedence rule, without inferring intentional disrespect.

6.7. Incorrect Display of the French Flag

During a protocol meeting between French Ambassador Christian Thimonier and the President of the Ohrid Municipal Council, Živka Angeloska, in July 2019, the Dutch flag was displayed on the table in place of the French tricolour (Time.mk, 2019). The three colours of the French and Dutch flags are identical (blue, white and red), differing only in their orientation (vertical bands versus horizontal bands) — a difference small enough to escape a hurried visual check but large enough, once noticed, to register as an unmistakable error. It is worth noting that this incident occurred at the level of local self-government protocol rather than within the state-level apparatus examined in the preceding cases; this does not diminish its relevance to the paper's thesis, since it demonstrates that the same systemic vulnerability — absence of verification, absence of a designated responsible officer — extends across institutional levels, from central ministries to municipal administration.

6.8. The Danish Flag Displayed Instead of the Swiss Flag — Ukraine, 2014

On 14 April 2014, during a visit by Didier Burkhalter — President of the Swiss Confederation for 2014 and OSCE Chairperson-in-Office — to Kyiv for talks with Ukraine's then Prime Minister Arseniy Yatsenyuk, the Danish flag stood in the background in place of the Swiss flag during the two leaders' handshake — the single most photographed moment of the meeting (Washington Post, 2014). The Swiss flag is a square white cross on a red field; the Danish flag is a rectangular white Scandinavian cross on a red field — the two share an identical colour scheme and a cross motif, differing only in proportions and in the cross's extension to the flag's edge, a distinction fine enough that Ukrainian protocol staff evidently did not catch it during preparation. Burkhalter himself noticed the error and pointed it out to Yatsenyuk in a moment that Swiss media reported he treated with good humour rather than diplomatic protest (Moscow Times, 2014). Smiljanov (2021b: 91) cites this case in the context of the thesis that flag protocol errors are a universal phenomenon and not a specificity of smaller or less experienced administrations — a claim that this incident, involving the OSCE's own Chairperson-in-Office on an internationally watched mediation visit, supports more strongly than almost any other case in this corpus. The case demonstrates that this is a systemic vulnerability wherever verification procedures are inadequate, regardless of the level or prestige of the event.

6.9. International Comparative Perspective: Beyond North Macedonia

Two further internationally documented incidents — outside the core domestic corpus and included for comparative breadth — confirm that flag-protocol failure is not bound to one region, administration or level of diplomatic experience.

In April-May 2026, during the state visit of King Charles III to the United States, Washington authorities mistakenly displayed Australian flags rather than Union Jacks along a street ahead of the King's arrival, an error attributed to the visual similarity of the flags' upper-left cantons and corrected after detection (CBC News, 2026). Fact-checking also distinguished this verified street-display error from separate office-building images circulating online that were attributed to an earlier context (Snopes, 2026). This distinction was retained in the present paper to avoid relying on visually attractive but factually unstable evidence. Days later, at Arlington National Cemetery, the Union Jack was reportedly carried upside down during a farewell ceremony (People, 2026). The two errors are used here cautiously: together, they show that even highly resourced protocol systems can fail if a final visual check is absent.

In November 2018, during the state visit of Chinese President Xi Jinping to the Philippines,

observers noted that the Chinese flag had been placed in the observer's-left position — the position of honour reserved for the host country's own flag — at the gates of the Malacañang Palace and during the bilateral meeting itself, displacing the Philippine flag to the right, in apparent breach of Section 18 of Republic Act No. 8491, which mandates that the Philippine flag occupy the observer's left when displayed alongside a single foreign flag (Philippine Daily Inquirer, 2018). Commentators also noted that the honour guard carried the flag of China rather than the Presidential Standard during the welcome ceremony, a further departure from established practice (Philippine Daily Inquirer, 2018). The case is instructive precisely because the Philippines, like North Macedonia, regulates flag protocol through an explicit, codified statute; the existence of the law did not, on this occasion, prevent its breach at the point of ceremonial execution. It is also worth noting, for comparative precision, that Philippine law fixes the host flag at the observer's left without the visiting-state exception this paper's own guide identifies for North Macedonian practice in section 7.3, underscoring that the precedence convention itself, not merely its enforcement, varies across jurisdictions. Taken together with the seven core North Macedonian cases and the detailed Swiss-Ukrainian comparator, these two examples support the broader claim: the determining factor in flag-protocol failure is not the wealth, size or diplomatic experience of the host administration, but the presence or absence of a mandatory, independently verified checkpoint immediately before ceremonial display. Their inclusion is deliberately limited; they provide corroborating breadth rather than the deeper domestic evidence on which the main analysis rests. This restrained use is important for methodological integrity: the paper does not claim that all political systems fail in the same way, only that the same class of preventable visual errors appears across different institutional environments when the final verification step is weak.

7. HOW THE FLAG MUST BE DISPLAYED: AN INTEGRATED OPERATIONAL PROTOCOL GUIDE

Based on the cases analysed and the normative framework, this chapter synthesises the rules into an operational guide for protocol officers, grounded in Articles 16-24 of the Law and the Military Protocol Rulebook (Trajanoski, 2018), and consistent with standard protocol reference works (McCaffree et al., 2002). The guide may be read across three operational phases: pre-event preparation, live-event execution and institutional follow-through. It is deliberately practical because the cases reviewed above show that legal rules alone do not prevent errors at the point of execution. The mandatory double check in section 7.7 applies the four-eyes principle: no single individual's verification is sufficient before an official flag display, regardless of rank or experience.

7.1. Article 24 — Prohibitions

The flag **MUST NOT** be used: (a) as drapery, curtain or covering; (b) folded in the form of a wreath or gathered; (c) as decoration on pillows, handkerchiefs, napkins, paper boxes, undergarments or disposable items. When displayed, it must not touch any object beneath it. When lowered, no part may touch the floor. When removed from the flagpole, it must be folded neatly and ceremonially.

7.2. Articles 18-20 — Mandatory Honours during Raising and Lowering

The flag is raised briskly and lowered slowly and ceremonially. During raising and lowering: all present stand to attention facing the flag; male persons wearing any form of headwear must remove it; persons in military uniform render a military salute. The anthem is played only when the flag is at the top of the flagpole — not at half-mast. Article 19 specifies that outdoor flagpole display runs between sunrise and sunset, except where the flag is illuminated for continuous twenty-four-hour display.

7.3. Articles 16-17 — Display alongside Foreign Flags

Alongside one foreign flag: the national flag is on the left as viewed from the front. Exception: during an official visit, the national flag may be placed to the right of the visiting state's flag, viewed from the front. Alongside two other flags: the national flag is in the centre. Alongside several foreign flags: the foreign flags follow Macedonian alphabetical order. When the flags are displayed in a row, Article 16(1)(4) requires the Macedonian flag to occupy the first place in the row, namely the left side as viewed from the front. No other flag may be larger or higher than the national flag. This rule is directly relevant for summit-stage arrangements, outdoor flag rows and multilateral photographic backdrops.

7.4. Article 21 — Indoor Display

The flag is always placed to the right as viewed from the speaker's position (which corresponds to the audience's left, consistent with the convention followed in most national flag codes) — not from the audience's own vantage point. Local self-government or other flags stand to the left, at a distance of 2 metres, 1 metre lower and in smaller dimensions.

7.5. Article 22 — Display on Motor Vehicles

When carried on an official vehicle, the flag is mounted on the right side of the chassis as viewed from the front of the vehicle, on a fixed staff that does not obstruct the driver's field of view.

7.6. Article 23 — Half-Mast and Funerary Display

At half-mast, the flag is first raised briskly to the top of the pole and then lowered slowly to the half-mast position; the reverse sequence is followed before it is finally lowered. On a casket during a state or military funeral, the flag is placed with the upper left corner (as viewed by an observer facing the head of the casket) over the left shoulder of the deceased.

7.7. Pre-Event Checklist for Protocol Officers

IDENTITY: Is this the correct flag for the correct state? Verify against an authoritative visual reference — never from memory, and never solely from a flag's general color scheme, given how many of the cases above turned on near-identical color combinations.

ORIENTATION: Is the flag correctly oriented? For flags with coats of arms, confirm which end is up; for flags with crosses or other axis-sensitive emblems, confirm the correct proportion and placement of the design relative to the flag's edge.

POSITION: Is the national flag in the correct precedence position?

ORDER: Multiple foreign flags — are they in the correct Macedonian alphabetical order?

DIMENSIONS: Are all flags of equal size? Reference dimensions (Trajanoski, 2018): 3.2 x 1.6 m (General Staff); 2.4 x 1.2 m (garrison entrances); 5 x 2.5 m (poles over

15 m); 2 x 1 m (indoors).

CONDITION: Clean, undamaged, no tears or fading.

CONTACT: Does the flag touch the ground or any object? Correct immediately.

DOUBLE CHECK (four-eyes principle): A second person, independent of whoever performed the first check, verifies all of the above against the official programme of the event, not from memory of a previous, similar event.

7.8. Institutional Responsibility and Training

The cases reviewed in section 6 share a common institutional pattern: responsibility for flag verification was either undefined or distributed across more than one service without a single accountable owner. An integrated operational approach therefore requires one named flag-protocol officer per event; refresher training before periods of compressed diplomatic scheduling; and a photographed, dated and verified catalogue of all flags likely to be used. This catalogue can be a simple shared digital folder or tablet checklist with high-resolution images of orientation-sensitive details. It should show not only the full flag but also enlarged details such as coats of arms, cross proportions, cantons and correct vertical orientation. Its purpose is practical: under time pressure, staff tend to verify a flag by dominant colours rather than full design, and a side-by-side reference makes that shortcut harder to miss.

Training should address the cognitive failure mode revealed by the cases: personnel often verify a flag by colour family rather than complete design. Effective exercises should therefore use historically confusing pairs — red-white-red tricolours, blue-white-red tricolours and white-cross-on-red designs — so that officers learn not only individual flags but also the categories of visual confusion most likely to defeat a hurried check.

8. DISCUSSION

Not every flag error is intentional. Causes include rushed organisation, weak oversight, insufficient training and the absence of a clearly designated responsible person. Yet in public and diplomatic space, perception is often more consequential than intent. The cases reveal a recurring pattern: errors occur with visually similar flags, during compressed preparation windows or where oversight is fragmented. They also show that institutional responses differ: some cases produced an apology, one produced a resignation, and others produced no visible public response even though the image remained in circulation. Table 1 summarises these ten cases by mechanism, institutional level and response; those patterns structure the analysis that follows.

Political semiotics clarifies why the reaction is disproportionate to the technical cause. Edelman's (1964) condensation symbol explains why a flag stands for the entire relationship between states, while Goffman's (1974) frame analysis shows how a diplomatic welcome depends on the correct performance of expected elements. Once the flag is wrong, observers do not see an isolated technical slip; they reread the whole ceremony through the breach. This is why the distinction between intention and effect must remain central. A government may intend respect, but the visual frame may communicate disorder, neglect or indifference. Across the ten cases examined, the damage was real even where intent was absent, confirming the paper's central hypothesis.

The case-to-theory mapping can be stated directly. Case 6.1 (Austria/Latvia) illustrates Jervis's (1970) signal/index distinction: the error was an involuntary disclosure of institutional unreadiness. Case 6.3 (Montenegro) illustrates Goffman's frame violation because it concerned orientation rather than identity. Case 6.2 (Slovenia/Slovakia) illustrates

Durkheim's sacred/profane boundary through the resignation that followed: the institution treated the breach as morally and symbolically serious, not merely as an inventory problem. Case 6.8 (Switzerland/Denmark) illustrates Edelman's condensation symbol, because a brief visual mistake became part of international press coverage of an important OSCE-related visit. The point is not that one theory explains one case exclusively, but that each framework helps isolate a different layer of the same phenomenon.

A second pattern concerns institutional capacity. If capacity alone prevented flag-protocol failure, the cases in section 6.9 would not exist. Their presence alongside the Macedonian cases and the Swiss-Ukrainian example suggests that the decisive variable is not the general sophistication of an institution, but whether a discrete, assigned and independently audited verification step exists at the point of execution. Highly developed protocol systems can still fail if they rely on assumption, habit or prior storage labels instead of direct visual confirmation. The policy implication is encouraging: the solution is procedural, not expensive.

A third observation concerns the asymmetry between prevention and correction. Visual cross-referencing, a second independent check and a written placement plan require little cost and can be performed by personnel already present. By contrast, the consequences documented in section 6 — formal apologies, resignation and negative media cycles — are reputationally expensive and may displace the substantive purpose of the event. In security-communication terms, the prevention cost is minimal while the correction cost is unpredictable. This asymmetry is the strongest argument for treating flag verification as mandatory procedure, not individual diligence.

The author's prior work also documents a non-flag coordination failure during the September 2018 visit of US Secretary of Defense James Mattis to Skopje, where the positioning of the red carpet reportedly created confusion between institutional protocol services (Smiljanov, 2021a, p. 62). The example is included only to illustrate the same diffusion-of-responsibility dynamic: when ceremonial functions are divided across institutions without one coordinator, visible error becomes more likely.

International law reinforces this expectation without replacing domestic procedure. Article 29 of the Vienna Convention on Consular Relations (1963) conditions the right to display a flag on respect for the receiving state's laws and usages, while Article 55 requires respect for those laws and usages more broadly. For the purposes of host-state protocol, the relevant conclusion is practical rather than formalistic: visiting state symbols must be handled with precision because media coverage converts a momentary logistical failure into a durable reputational event.

The findings can therefore be condensed into a four-stage risk chain. First, the legal rule defines the correct symbolic order. Second, the protocol service translates that rule into physical arrangement. Third, the public image fixes the arrangement as a visible statement. Fourth, media circulation separates the image from the institution's later explanation. Failure at the second stage is the point of highest preventive leverage: once the image enters the third and fourth stages, correction is possible but reputational containment is uncertain. This chain explains why the recommendations below focus less on punishment after error and more on verification before exposure.

9. RECOMMENDATIONS

In the short term, before the next high-level visit or multilateral event, protocol services should assemble a standardised and independently verified flag inventory; cross-check every flag against an authoritative visual reference, not against archival labels; require double visual verification by two independent persons; prepare a written and, where practicable, diagrammed placement plan; circulate it to all participating institutions; and designate one person or a small team with clear authority to halt a ceremony until a detected error is corrected. These measures should be documented as part of the event file so that later review can establish not only whether an error occurred, but whether the required preventive steps were actually performed. The most practical instrument is a one-page flag-risk sheet attached to every official event file: it should identify the required flags, the applicable precedence rule, the responsible officer, the independent verifier, the time of final inspection and the corrective authority empowered to stop display before public exposure.

In the longer term, institutions should invest in continuous, role-specific training of protocol personnel rather than general orientation sessions; build stronger inter-institutional coordination mechanisms between ministries, the military protocol service and local self-government, given that the cases examined span all three levels; and consider periodic, unannounced internal audits of flag-display readiness, modelled on the verification disciplines already used in other high-consequence ceremonial functions such as honour-guard drill. Training should be scenario-based rather than lecture-based: officers should work through simulated bilateral, multilateral, indoor, outdoor and vehicle-display situations, including cases where several institutions share responsibility for one ceremony. The value of such exercises is not only memorisation of rules but the creation of professional reflexes: verify identity, verify orientation, verify position, verify equality and document the check before the public moment begins. Such training should be assessed, not merely attended: officers should be required to demonstrate correct decisions under time pressure, with confusing flag pairs and incomplete room diagrams, because those are precisely the conditions under which the documented cases occurred.

Beyond these procedural measures, the cases point to a broader lesson for institutional resilience. Where responsibility for a symbolically sensitive function is distributed across more institutions than there are assigned points of accountability, the probability of visible failure rises regardless of individual competence. Protocol services should therefore map, for every recurring type of ceremonial event, which institution is accountable for each element and should close gaps before, rather than after, a failure occurs. The same logic applies beyond flags to anthem order, red-carpet placement, seating plans, honour guards and other visible elements of state ceremony. Flag management is therefore a useful diagnostic field for a wider problem of ceremonial risk governance. In practical terms, this means that protocol should be managed through a short pre-event risk file: the expected guests, flags required, placement diagram, responsible officer, verifier, time of final check and corrective authority. Such documentation is simple, but it transforms protocol from personal memory into institutional procedure. It also creates a clear audit trail for later learning.

10. CONCLUSION

A wrongly displayed flag may appear to be a technical mistake, but its consequences are never merely technical. The seven core North Macedonian cases created symbolic damage, media attention and, in several instances, the need for apology; in one case, accountability extended to the resignation of a protocol director. The detailed Swiss-Ukrainian comparator and the two concise international examples confirm that the vulnerability is not regional or developmental, but procedural. The empirical record therefore supports the central hypothesis in a limited but clear way: where the symbol is wrong, the public image of institutional readiness is damaged even when the error has no political intention behind it.

The cases examined — from Austria/Latvia and Slovakia/Slovenia to Montenegro, Bulgaria, the Open Balkan summit, France/Netherlands, Switzerland/Denmark, the United Kingdom/United States and China/Philippines — form a consistent pattern calling for systemic rather than reactive institutional responses. The common denominator is the absence of a standardised verification procedure and a clearly designated responsible person. The solution is organisational and educational, not technologically complex or financially demanding.

Protocol is not bureaucratic formality; it is the visible face of a state's seriousness in international relations. Every correctly displayed flag confirms institutional competence; every wrongly displayed flag says the opposite, regardless of intent. Because the consequences of negligence are disproportionate to the effort required to prevent it, flag management should be treated as a core element of diplomatic communication and security culture. The checklist in section 7.7 and the recommendations in section 9 are therefore designed for all levels at which the failure occurs: central government, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the military protocol service and municipal administration. The final lesson is simple but institutionally demanding: the state symbol must be checked before it is seen, because once it is seen incorrectly, the image has already become the message. In that sense, the flag is a small object with a large institutional function: it converts legal sovereignty into visible order.

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